



Q Being home with my baby is wonderful, but tiring. How can we make life easier?

While arriving home with your special-care baby is a joyful occasion, you may feel nervous about being in charge alone. Parents often find that it's only when they're home that the full force of what they've been through sinks in. Working through emotions and seeking support will help you manage.

Managing emotionally

It's very normal to begin a period of grief when you arrive home with your baby after his prolonged hospital stay—for your expectations of your first days, weeks, or months of your life as a family. You may feel anxious about the responsibility of taking care of your baby without constant medical support, and angry that life hasn't been as simple as it was supposed to be. Along



with frustration, guilt, confusion, irritability, and helplessness, these are perfectly normal reactions to your situation. The five-step plan, below, can help you work through complex feelings.

A close bond The time your older child spends with the new arrival, talking to and touching him, will help them form an enduring bond.

Your growing family

Welcoming a new baby into the family presents challenges, and when that baby needs extra care, challenges magnify. Be careful not to shut out older children. Involve them in the baby's care if you can: maybe they can help with sponge bathing or finding a diaper bag. You are bound to feel anxious about a two-year-old "cuddling" a premature infant, so set boundaries you're happy with. Be honest, but kind, and explain that the baby is tiny and has been sick, so only grown-ups can hold the baby for now, but he loves to have his head stroked or his hand held. Sing songs to the baby together, and tell your toddler how the baby loves to hear his voice and how this helps to make him better. Older children may feel confused if you are sad or irritable, and think the baby is sick because of something they've done. Reassure them that nothing that's happening is their fault. Say sorry if you're snappy, and explain that you're tired. Praise your children for any help they give you and try to spend dedicated time with them every day, even if this is just at bath- or bedtime.

FIVE-STEP PLAN

This simple five-step plan can help you work through the emotions you may feel about your baby needing special care. This isn't a cure-all, but one, some, or all of them may help you start to accept events and move forward.

1 Acknowledge your grief

If you knew before the birth that your baby would need extra care, you may be grieving for the loss of an easy-going pregnancy. If your baby was premature, you may grieve for the loss of those last weeks of pregnancy. Or you may grieve for the loss of those first moments after birth when you could be alone with your baby. Acknowledging that events represent a loss of the experiences you might have wished for is the first step to coping.

2 Express your emotions

The hospital can put you in touch with a therapist who has been trained to advise and help parents of special-care babies. Talking to someone who isn't emotionally involved can help you to rationalize how you feel. You can go with your partner, on your own, or a mixture of both. Keeping a journal of your baby's progress and how you feel provides a positive reminder of how far you've come.

3 Celebrate the successes

Successes don't have to be big things. The first time you manage a walk with your baby in the carriage, to give eye drops without forgetting to keep tissues beside you, to sit down with a slice of toast in the morning, to write a thank you card or two, are all steps towards "normal" life, which makes them successes worth celebrating. They will help to remind you that every day you can achieve something.

4 Ask for help

You don't need to be strong all the time. When possible, ask for help with the practical matters of being at home, so that you can focus on your baby and yourself. Ideally, someone else can do the cleaning, shopping, and cooking. Don't be shy about taking advantage of the resources of well-meaning friends and family, and accept all offers of practical help willingly.